



Frozen out

冰封的一代

难度评级：★★★★☆

Japan's Gen X workers are struggling

日本 X 世代劳动者举步维艰

【 Para.1 】

For nearly two decades Torigoe Atsushi, who is 50, has worked in the stockrooms of a fashion firm in Tokyo. His income rose only **modestly**, and it recently fell after his employer cut bonuses and reworked its pay scheme; he now earns about ¥3.6m (\$22,600) a year. Then he **spotted** the firm's recruitment ads, offering newcomers higher salaries. "It's great that younger people are getting better pay," he says. "But why not raise mine?"

50岁的鸟越敦在东京一家时装公司的仓库里工作了近二十年。他的收入涨幅有限，近来雇主削减奖金、调整薪酬方案后更是有所下降；如今他年收入约360万日元（约合22600美元）。后来他注意到公司的招聘广告给新人开出了更高的薪资。“年轻人拿到更好的薪酬，这当然好，”他说，“可为什么不多给我涨一些

文章导读：

鸟越敦在东京时装公司仓库工作近二十年，收入微薄，却见新人薪资更高。日本“冰河期”世代在经济泡沫破裂后步入职场，如今再度陷入困境。冰河期世代与前一代人的就业际遇形成鲜明对比。大量毕业生转向非正规就业，“飞特族”与“寄生单身”现象浮现。时间推移与劳动力短缺缓解了部分困境，但收入差距依旧。日本经济回暖，薪资上涨红利主要惠及年轻群体。冰河期世代面临养老金微薄、储蓄不足的养老隐忧。政府持续关注并出台三年帮扶计划，但尚需更多深层应对。

modestly adv. /'mɒdɪstli/ To a moderate degree; not extremely. 适度地，适中地

The company's profits grew **modestly** compared to last year. 这家公司的利润与去年相比仅适度增长。

spot v. /spɒt/ To see or notice someone or something, especially suddenly. 看见，发现 【考研大纲词汇】

She **spotted** a mistake in the financial report.
她发现了财务报告中的一处错误。

endure v. /ɪn'dʒʊə(r)/ To suffer something difficult or unpleasant patiently. 忍受，忍耐 【考研大纲词汇】

The refugees **endured** months of hardship before finding shelter. 难民们忍受了数月的困苦后才找到避难所。

deflation n. /di:'fleɪʃn/ A reduction in the amount of money in a country's economy, causing prices to fall. 通货紧缩

The country experienced severe **deflation** during the lost decade. 该国在“迷失的十年”期间经历了严重的通货紧缩。

cohort n. /'kəʊhɔ:t/ A group of people who share a common characteristic or experience. 一代人，同龄群体

This **cohort** of graduates faces a highly competitive job market. 这一届毕业生面临极具竞争力的就业市场。

bulge n. /bʌldʒ/ A rounded swelling that sticks out; a sudden temporary increase in number or amount. 凸起，鼓起；（数量的）突然激增，暴涨

The population **bulge** caused by the baby boom will soon reach retirement age.
婴儿潮造成的人口激增很快将达到退休年龄。

starkly adv. /stɑ:kli/ In a way that is very obvious and striking. 鲜明地，截然不同地

The two regions differ **starkly** in their economic development. 这两个地区在经济发展上截然不同。

呢？”

【 Para.2 】

Mr Torigoe belongs to Japan's "ice-age" generation: workers who entered the labour market between 1993 and 2004, after the country's economic bubble burst and many companies stopped hiring. The ice-agers often **endured** years of insecure work and low pay. Now in their 40s and 50s (thus Generation X), they are losing out again. Japan is emerging from decades of **deflation**, prices are rising and companies are handing out their biggest pay increases in a generation. But the ice-agers are not benefiting. Worse may come when this **cohort** of baby-boomers' children—the last **bulge** in Japan's population pyramid—drifts into retirement.

鸟越先生属于日本的“冰河”世代——即在1993年至2004年间步入劳动力市场的一批劳动者，当时日本经济泡沫破裂，众多企业停止招聘。冰河世代常年经历工作不稳定、收入低下的困境。如今他们已经四五十岁（即X世代），却再度沦为输家。日本正走出持续数十年的通缩，物价上涨，企业正发放一代人以来最大幅度的加薪。然而冰河世代并未从中受益。更糟的情况或许还在后头：当这代婴儿潮子女（日本人口金字塔中最后一个人口高峰）逐渐步入退休时，情况可能会进一步恶化。

【 Para.3 】

The ice-agers' fortunes contrast **starkly** with those of the generation that came just before. During the bubble years of the 1980s, companies hired **voraciously**. College students

voraciously adv. /və'reɪfəsli/ Eagerly and in large amounts. 贪婪地，大量地

The startup consumed capital **voraciously** in its early years. 这家初创企业早期贪婪地消耗资本。

woo v. /wu:/ To try to persuade someone to support you or to do business with you. 争取，拉拢

Tech companies **woo** top talent with generous stock options. 科技公司以丰厚的股权激励拉拢顶尖人才。

distinguish v. /drɪ'stɪŋɡwɪʃ/ To recognize the difference between two things. 区分，辨别 【考研大纲词汇】

It is important to **distinguish** between correlation and causation in research.

在研究中，区分相关性与因果关系十分重要。

supplement v. /'sʌplɪmənt/ To add something to something else in order to improve it or increase its size. 补充 【考研大纲词汇】

She **supplements** her income by tutoring on weekends. 她周末做家教以补充收入。

reclusive adj. /rɪ'kluːsɪv/ Living a solitary life and avoiding other people. 隐居的，遁世的

The **reclusive** author rarely appeared in public events. 这位隐居的作家极少在公开场合露面。

acute adj. /ə'kjuːt/ Very serious or severe. 严重的，急剧的 【考研大纲词汇】

The country faces an **acute** shortage of medical professionals. 该国面临医务专业人才的严重短缺。

mobility n. /məʊ'bɪləti/ The ability to move easily between different levels of society or jobs. 流动性 【考研大纲词汇】

Social **mobility** has declined in many developed countries. 许多发达国家的社会流动性有所下降。

stagnation n. /stæg'neɪʃn/ A period of no growth or development. 停滞，不景气

The economy showed signs of **stagnation** in the third quarter. 经济在第三季度显现出停滞迹象。

incentive n. /ɪn'sentɪv/ Something that encourages a person to do something. 激励，刺激 【考研大纲词汇】

Tax cuts serve as an **incentive** for small businesses to invest. 减税为小企业投资提供了激励。

nominal adj. /'nɒmɪnəl/ In name only; not real or actual. 名义上的，票面上的 【考研大纲词汇】

He is the **nominal** head of the company but has little real power. 他名义上是公司负责人，但实际权力有限。

loom v. /luːm/ To appear as a shadowy form, especially one that is large and threatening. 笼罩，逼近 【考研大纲词汇】

A crisis **looms** as the aging population puts pressure on healthcare. 随着人口老龄化加压医疗体系，危机正在笼罩。

found their mailboxes stuffed with offer letters, or were treated to fancy meals by employers keen to **woo** them. Everything changed as the bubble popped in the early 1990s. Japan's rigid employment system made it hard for firms to shed existing workers, so they cut hiring instead. The ratio of job openings to college applicants fell from nearly three at its peak to below one by 2000. Nagai Toshihisa, who graduated in 1999, shortly after the Asian financial crisis, abandoned his hope of working for a securities firm. "It felt utterly stupid looking for jobs," he recalls. Many in his generation sent out dozens, even hundreds, of applications, to no avail. It did not help that the ice-age cohort was such a big one, adding to the oversupply. 冰河世代的际遇与前一代人形成鲜明对比。在20世纪80年代的泡沫经济时期，企业大举招人。大学生邮箱里塞满了录用通知，企业还会设宴款待，极力招揽他们。然而泡沫在90年代初破裂后，一切都变了。日本僵化的用工制度使企业难以裁撤现有员工，于是只能缩减招聘规模。岗位与求职者之比从峰值时的近3:1跌至2000年的不足1:1。1999年毕业、恰逢亚洲金融危机之后的永井俊久，放弃了进入证券公司工作的念头。“那时候找工作简直荒唐得可笑，”他回忆道。他这一代人中许多人投出了数十封乃至上百封申请，都石沉大海。雪上加霜的是，冰河世代本身规模庞大，进一步加剧了供过于求的局面。

【 Para.4 】

Many graduates who failed to secure regular jobs ended up in temporary or contract work. Japan's labour market sharply **distinguishes** between regular workers, who enjoy

suppress v. /sə'pres/ To prevent something from growing, developing or functioning freely. 压制，抑制 【考研大纲词汇】

The government **suppressed** wages to maintain export competitiveness. 政府压制工资以维持出口竞争力。

lament v. /lə'ment/ To express sadness or regret about something. 哀叹，惋惜

The mayor **lamented** the decline of the historic downtown area. 市长对古城商业区的衰败感到惋惜。

woe n. /wəʊ/ Problems or troubles. 烦恼，灾难

The company's financial **woes** led to massive layoffs. 公司的财务困境导致大规模裁员。

nudge v. /nʌdʒ/ To push someone gently, especially to encourage them to do something. 轻推，促使

The teacher **nudged** the students towards reading more classic literature. 老师循循善诱，引导学生多读经典文学。

reclusive adj. /rɪ'kluːsɪv/ Living a solitary life and avoiding other people. 隐居的，遁世的，深居简出的

He led a **reclusive** life after retiring from the film industry. 从电影圈退休后，他过起了深居简出的生活

belatedly adv. /brɪ'leɪtɪdli/ Happening later than expected. 迟来地，并非及时地

The government **belatedly** acknowledged the severity of the housing crisis. 政府迟来地承认了住房危机的严重程度。

➤ 今日句子分析

主句

According to Kumano Hideo, an economist at Dai-ichi Life

Research Institute, nominal wages for college-educated workers in

their 20s and 30s were 10-16% higher in 2025 than five

years earlier (系动词) 表语 时间状语 比较状语

主句：

状语 - According to Kumano Hideo (介词短语作状语)；

同位语 - an economist (作 Kumano Hideo 的同位语)；

后置定语 - at Dai-ichi Life Research Institute (介词短语作后置定语，修饰 economist)；

主语 - nominal wages；

后置定语 - for college-educated workers in their 20s and 30s (介词短语作后置定语，修饰 wages)；

strong legal protections and seniority-based pay rises, and irregular ones, who often do similar work for much less money and are the first to be laid off in downturns. Such jobs often used to be filled by housewives **supplementing** their husbands' salaries. Increasingly, they were taken by young people who needed to support themselves, says Kondo Ayako of the University of Tokyo. The term "freeters"—youngsters drifting between casual jobs—became popular, as did "parasite singles", who lived off their parents well into adulthood. There was also growing concern about hikikomori, social **recluses**.

许多未能找到正式工作的毕业生最终从事临时工或合同工。日本劳动力市场对正式员工与非正式员工有着严格的区分：正式员工享有完备的法律保障和基于工龄的加薪机制，而非正式员工虽然往往从事类似工作，薪酬却低得多，且在经济低谷时最先被裁。这类岗位过去多由贴补丈夫收入的家庭主妇担任。东京大学的近藤绫子指出，越来越多需要自力更生的年轻人开始从事这些工作。“飞特族”（freeters）一词广为流行，意为辗转于各类零工之间的年轻人；“寄生单身族”，即成年后仍依赖父母生活的人，同样流行。社会对“蛰居族”（hikikomori）的担忧也日益加剧。

【 Para.5 】

Time and **acute** labour shortages have repaired some of the damage. The share of ice-agers in regular employment has largely caught up with that of older cohorts, says Shimoda Yusuke of the Japan Research Institute. But their earnings have not. Those who spent long stretches in irregular work tend not to fully catch up even after switching to the regular

系动词 - were（系动词）；

表语 - 10-16% higher（形容词短语作表语）；

时间状语 - in 2025（介词短语作时间状语）；

比较状语 - than five years earlier（than 引导比较状语）。

翻译技巧解析：该句代词 Kumano Hideo 后跟有同位语和后置定语，若直译为“熊野秀男，第一生命经济研究所的经济学家”，中文定语过于冗长。翻译时将较长的同位语和后置定语调整至主语前，使其符合中文的定语前置习惯，即“第一生命经济研究所经济学家熊野秀男”。主语后的后置定语“for college-educated workers in their 20s and 30s”较长，可将其转化为“拥有大学学历的二三十岁劳动者”这一定语前置，避免译文拼凑。比较结构“higher...than”直译为“高于”即可，简洁明了。

写作积累

(Para.2) Worse may come when this cohort of baby-boomers' children—the last bulge in Japan's population pyramid—drifts into retirement.

drift into retirement v. phr. To gradually enter retirement without a clear plan or transition. 逐渐步入退休状态。在原文中特指日本婴儿潮子孙辈随着年龄增长而逐渐退出劳动力市场，这里的 drift 带有一定的消极或被动色彩，暗示这一过程缓慢且缺乏主动规划。

类似的表达还有：

fade into retirement 渐渐退休。例：Many baby boomers are fading into retirement rather than stopping work abruptly. 许多婴儿潮一代是渐渐退休而非骤然停工。（与 drift into 的区别在于，fade into 更强调从活跃到消退的渐变过程，而 drift into 更强调随波逐流的被动感。）

slide into retirement 滑入退休。例：He slid into retirement after the company downsized. 公司精简后他顺势滑入了退休状态。

语言知识补充：动词 drift 本义为“漂流、随波逐流”，引申为“无意中漂到某种状态”。常用搭配还有：drift apart（渐行渐远）；drift off（不知不觉地入睡）；let things drift（听之任之、放任自流）。这些用法均保留了“缓慢、无明确方向”的核心语义。

(Para.6) Companies short of labour are competing fiercely for fresh blood, and paying more to attract and retain it.

fresh blood n. New employees, especially young ones who bring energy and new ideas. 新鲜血液，新生力量。在原文中特指企业想要招募的年轻劳动者，强调其年轻、有活力的特点，相较于更为中性的 new employees 或 new hires, fresh blood 带有比喻色彩，暗示新鲜血液能为组织注入活力。

类似的表达还有：

new blood n. 新鲜血液。与 fresh blood 同义，可交替使用。例：The manager said the team needed some new blood to stay competitive. 经理说团队需要注入些新鲜血液才能保持竞争力。

infusion of new talent 新人才的注入。更正式的表达，常用于企业招募语境。例：The company is seeking an infusion of new talent for its AI division. 公司正为AI业务部门寻求新人才的注入。

track. Those in regular jobs faced another problem: the upper ranks of their companies were crowded with the bubble-era workers, delaying promotions for those who followed. Japan's low labour **mobility** has meant the unlucky cohort cannot easily seek better pay elsewhere.

时间推移和严重的劳动力短缺在一定程度上修复了创伤。日本综合研究所的下田佑介表示，冰河世代中正式就业的比例已基本追上年长的群体。但他们的收入却没有。长期从事非正规工作的人即便后来转入正式岗位，收入也难以完全追平。而拥有正式岗位的冰河世代还面临另一个难题：公司高层已被泡沫经济时期的员工占满，推迟了后来者的晋升。日本劳动力流动性偏低，意味着这一不幸群体难以轻易另谋高就。

【 Para.6 】

Japan's economy is changing. After three decades of **stagnation**, wages are rising as inflation returns, and job-hopping is becoming more common. Yet these improvements are mostly benefiting the young. Companies short of labour are competing fiercely for fresh blood, and paying more to attract and retain it. Middle-aged employees are much less likely to switch jobs, giving firms little **incentive** to raise their wages. According to Kumano Hideo, an economist at Dai-ichi Life Research Institute, **nominal** wages for college-educated workers in their 20s and 30s were 10-16% higher in 2025 than five years earlier. Meanwhile, those in their early 50s suffered a **nominal** decline of 1.3%. Abe Katsuya, 48, says the

语言知识补充：“fresh blood”本义指医学上的输血血液，引申为组织管理中的“新鲜血液”，属于隐喻表达。类似的“血液”隐喻还有：bad blood（恩怨、不和）；in the blood（天生的、骨子里的），如：Music is in her blood. 音乐是她天生的才能。

large pay rises dished out to the young give him “mixed feelings”. He is part of the “Mammoth Club”, a support group for ice-agers who identify with the woolly beasts that endured harsh times.

日本经济正在变化。经过三十年的停滞，通胀再度到来，工资开始上涨，跳槽也愈发普遍。然而这些改善主要惠及年轻人。劳动力短缺的企业正激烈争夺新鲜血液，并以更高薪酬吸引和留住他们。中年员工跳槽意愿远低于年轻人，企业因此缺乏为其加薪的动力。第一生命经济研究所的经济学家熊野秀男指出，2025年拥有大学学历的二三十岁劳动者的名义工资较五年前高出10%至16%。与此同时，50岁出头的群体名义工资却下降了1.3%。48岁的阿部胜也说，年轻人获得的大幅加薪令他五味杂陈。他加入了“猛犸象俱乐部”——一个冰河世代的互助组织，成员们自比为曾在严酷环境中幸存的猛犸象。

【 Para.7 】

All this has left the ice-agers with low lifetime earnings (and therefore little in the way of savings). That points to a **looming** crisis as they reach old age. Japan's pension system ties payouts to lifetime earnings, so decades of **suppressed** pay will translate

into low pensions. “Those who happened to come of age in a downturn are likely to carry that handicap for the rest of their lives,” **laments** Mr Kumano. Getting them to work longer, as a growing number of old people already do, is one fix but it will not solve everything. Ms Kondo warns that many may end up on welfare, which is not designed to support the elderly over extended periods. That would be costly; for instance, the state pays welfare recipients’ medical bills in full. And because the generations behind the ice-agers are smaller, fewer workers will have to support more pensioners.

这一切使得冰河世代终身收入偏低（因此储蓄也所剩无几）。随着他们步入老年，一场危机正悄然逼近。日本的养老金制度将发放金额与终身收入挂钩，因此数十年薪酬持续低迷将转化为微薄的养老金。“那些恰逢经济低谷期步入成年的群体，很可能终其一生都要背负这一劣势，”熊野先生哀叹道。延长工作年限是一种应对之策，越来越多的老年人已经在这样做，但这并不能解决所有问题。近藤女士警告说，许多人最终可能不得不依靠社会救济度日，而救济制度本并非为长期赡养老年人而设计。这将代价高昂，例如，国家需全额承担救济对象的医疗费用。而且由于冰河世代之后的各代人口更少，越来越少的劳动者将不得不供养越来越多的养老金领取者。

【 Para.8 】

The **woes** of the ice-age generation have long had the government’s attention. For decades, authorities have come up with programmes to help them find jobs and **nudge reclusive** ones to connect with the outside world. Yet as the ice-agers grow older they face new problems. Beyond thin pensions and savings, questions loom, for instance, over housing; compared with older Japanese, this cohort is less likely to own homes, and Japan’s rental market is unfriendly towards older tenants. The government is **belatedly** adjusting: in April, it produced a three-year plan for the ice-agers, spanning measures from asset-building to housing. But a lot more serious thinking will be needed.

冰河世代的困境早已引起政府关注。数十年来，相关部门推出了一系列项目，帮助他们就业，并引导蛰居者与外界接触。然而随着冰河世代日渐年迈，他们又面临新的难题。除了微薄的养老金与储蓄之外，住房问题也日益突出。与年长的日本人相比，这一群体拥有房产的比例更低，而日本的租房市场对高龄租客并不友好。政府正在亡羊补牢式地调整：今年4月出台了一份面向冰河世代的三年计划，涵盖从资产积累到住房保障的诸多措施。但真正需要的是更多严肃而深入的思考。